



# Emergency Signal Quick Reference

Pierce County 4x4 Search & Rescue | [piercecounity4x4sar.org](http://piercecounity4x4sar.org)

EMERGENCY

CALL 911

## IF YOU'RE LOST: S.T.O.P.

### S -- SIT DOWN

Stop moving. Panic is your enemy. Every wrong step takes you farther from where rescuers will look.

### T -- THINK

When did you last know your location? Can you retrace your steps safely and confidently?

### O -- OBSERVE

Landmarks, trail markers, sounds of roads or water. Check your map and compass carefully.

### P -- PLAN

If unsure, STAY PUT. Make yourself visible and signal for help. We search your planned route first.

### #1 RULE: STAY PUT

80% of lost hikers are found within 1 mile of their last known position -- when they don't wander. Moving makes it exponentially harder to find you.

## AUDIO SIGNALS

- ☐ **Whistle (BEST):** 3 short blasts, pause, repeat. Heard up to 1 mile. Uses almost no energy. Always carry one.
- ☐ **Voice:** Shout 'HELP' in groups of 3. Cup hands, aim toward sounds. Save your voice -- a whistle is 10x better.

## VISUAL SIGNALS

- ☐ **Signal mirror:** Flash toward aircraft/ridgelines. Visible up to 10 miles on clear day. Any shiny surface works.
- ☐ **Bright colors:** Spread gear in open areas. Wave bright items overhead when you hear or see searchers.
- ☐ **Fire / smoke:** Fire visible at night; smoke during day. Add green branches for white smoke. 3 fires in triangle = SOS.
- ☐ **Ground symbols:** Make 10+ ft tall, high contrast to ground. X = need medical help. V = need assistance. SOS = distress.

## ELECTRONIC + SATELLITE

- ☐ **Cell phone:** Try 911 even with no bars -- connects via ANY carrier. Text 911 if voice call fails.
- ☐ **Satellite 911 texting:** FREE for all carriers via T-Mobile/Starlink (emergency 911 only). Full messaging: \$10/mo.
- ☐ **iPhone 14+ SOS:** Built-in satellite SOS, no subscription. Practice: Settings > Emergency SOS > Try Demo.
- ☐ **Android SOS:** Pixel 9+, Galaxy S25+ support satellite emergency messaging via phone settings.
- ☐ **Garmin inReach:** Two-way satellite texting + SOS with 24/7 monitoring center. ~\$15/mo subscription.
- ☐ **Battery saving:** Airplane mode between 911 attempts. Reduce brightness. Texting uses less power than calls.



FREE Satellite 911 (all carriers)

<https://www.t-mobile.com/coverage/satellite-phone-servi>



Garmin inReach Mini 2

<https://www.garmin.com/en-US/p/765374>